

high-speed buses, and open, user-defined software, modular instrumentation is best suited to meet the needs of test and measurement today and in the future. NI modular instruments are the building blocks of economical and versatile automated test systems. With modular instruments, you can choose from a wide variety of measurement, signal generation, RF, power and switch modules and then configure the instruments in software to meet your specific measurement tasks. Because these instruments are modular and software-defined, they are quickly interchanged and easily repurposed to meet evolving test needs. Additionally, NI modular instruments provide high-speed test execution by harnessing the power of industry-standard PC and advanced timing and synchronisation technologies. Options are available for a variety of platforms including PXI, PXI Express, PCI, PCI Express and USB," informs Nandini Subramanya, senior marketing communications manager, National Instruments India.

With the availability of improved semiconductor devices in smaller sizes, T&M instruments have not only become cost-effective but also smaller in size and better in performance.

"Digital storage oscilloscope is a good example. The MDO 4000 mixed-domain oscilloscope from Tektronix combines digital storage oscilloscope and spectrum analyser functions in a single unit. Scientech's i-series products, viz, Caddo 831i oscilloscope, 4064i function generator and 4074i programmable power supply, offer digital read-out and Ethernet connectivity," explains J.K. Baldua, director-technical, Scientech Technologies.

Agilent Technologies works closely with various standards and organisations and helps users with innovative and reliable test products.

Sadaf Arif Siddiqui, technical marketing specialist, Agilent Technologies India, informs, "Be it a basic test instrument or a high-performance instrument, we go hand-in-hand with technological advancements across all segments. A typical example is the upgradeability feature, which is present in our entire range of oscilloscopes, spectrum analysers and network analysers. We have also incorporated some unique features in our products, such as OLEDs in digital multimeters, no fans and no vents in handheld spectrum analysers, and function generator in benchtop oscilloscopes."

Overcoming the challenges

Production volumes for T&M instruments are generally much lower than for consumer devices like PCs, smartphones and tablet computers. This means that leading-edge features common to these consumer devices, such as capacitive touchscreen interfaces and super-high-resolution colour screens, aren't as affordable for T&M applications.

T&M instruments need to be designed with industrial-grade components that remain available for many years for design stability reasons. One reason why industrial products are typically a few generations behind consumer devices as far as interfaces and related elements are concerned is the

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